had just read the interview I'd done with Hersch for *GQ* magazine. In it, for the first time, Hersch talked openly about his time in rehab.

'*Kom nou, Smitty man, fok,*' said Piet in his usual forthright manner, '*dis nou tyd om a bladdy book te skryf. Vra vir Gibbs.*' Something like that … My Afrikaans is pretty bad, but he does call me Smitty and he loves saying 'fok'.

The very next day I emailed Marlene Fryer at Zebra Press.

And it's her I want to thank next. Marlene is this book's publisher and, while she knew a Herschelle Gibbs autobiography would make for interesting reading, she took a chance on me as the writer. This is my first book. Thanks for the faith, Marlene. Thanks too to your very efficient and professional team – Robert Plummer for helping me shape the book, Ronel Richter-Herbert for her editing (I take almost as many liberties with the English language as I do with Afrikaans), and Kim Taylor for making sure the world knows about it all.

To my family – Medina and Holly. If it wasn't for you, Dee, I would have been a lawyer. Ja. Words aren't enough. And Holly, thank you for remaining the cheerful little imp you are, especially through those months when the only sign of your dad was the clicking sound of my laptop's keyboard.

To Donné Commins, Herschelle's manager, thanks for all your help and insights. All professional athletes should find themselves someone like Donné. She looks out for her players like they are her own family. She's helluva nice. But fierce too. The perfect combination for the business she's in.

And finally to Herschelle. It can't be easy to sit down with someone you only sort of know and tell them the warts-and-all story of your life. That's pretty ballsy. So thanks, Hersch. Thanks for making the time in your hectic schedule and thanks for trusting me to tell it like you told it.

STEVE SMITH
September 2010